# WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

*Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets*

# GUADELOUPE

Americas

*Information current as of October 2026*

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

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## WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

### KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

| Location / Region | Strategic Importance | Priority Sectors |
|---|---|---|
| Jarry / Baie-Mahault (Guadeloupe Port Caraïbes) | Main port and business zone; new ship-to-shore cranes entered service in 2025 and the €180 million Quai 12 extension, due by mid-2027, supports the ambition to become a Caribbean transshipment hub | Port logistics, transshipment, distribution, light industry |
| Pointe-à-Pitre / Les Abymes | Commercial centre and air gateway; Maryse Condé airport handled 2.1 million passengers in 2025, and a €44 million Novotel is planned for end-2028 | Aviation, retail, business services, hospitality |
| Basse-Terre | Administrative capital and seat of the Prefecture, the Région and the Département | Public services, administration, construction |
| Bouillante (west coast) | Geothermal plant producing 15.5 MW, about 10% of electricity needs, with a target of 50 MW by 2030 backed by €25.2 million from Banque des Territoires and Bpifrance | Geothermal energy, engineering, drilling services |
| Le Moule (Grande-Terre east) | Home to Albioma's 102 MW power plant, converted fully to biomass in 2025 and supplying about 30% of the island's electricity, and to a €32 million Pullman wellness resort due end-2026 | Renewable energy, sugar and rum, tourism |
| Saint-François and the south Grande-Terre coast | Leading resort area, where a €90 million five-star hotel by the Karukera group is due by end-2028 | Tourism, hospitality, nautical leisure, real estate |
| Basse-Terre island agricultural belt | Banana and agricultural heartland, where banana exports rose 2.2% in 2025 and a €110 million Boucan–Sainte-Rose bypass is planned | Agri-food, agro-processing, road infrastructure |

### INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Région Guadeloupe, which leads economic development, offers grants such as ARICE (40% of eligible investment, up to €40,000) and has entrusted €21 million to Bpifrance for 2025–2028 guarantee, loan and innovation funds

- Tax-free business zones (ZFANG): a 50% profit abatement (capped at €150,000), rising to 80% (capped at €300,000) for priority sectors including tourism, renewable energy, agro-nutrition, R&D, ICT, industry and naval repair, for SMEs with fewer than 250 staff
- National overseas productive-investment tax aid (article 199 undecies B of the General Tax Code), which also defines the sectors eligible for ZFANG relief
- Full French and EU legal framework: the euro is the currency, IEDOM acts as the Banque de France's local arm, and there are no capital controls or repatriation restrictions
- Public co-financing from Bpifrance, Banque des Territoires, AFD and EU regional funds, which support projects such as the port extension and geothermal expansion
- Public procurement in water and infrastructure, including the €320 million Plan Eau 2024–2027 and a new public water utility due to take over on 1 January 2027
- Geothermal exploration and production permits under the French Mining Code for investors in the island's renewable-energy expansion

### MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Guadeloupe offers investors a euro-denominated, French and EU jurisdiction at the heart of the Eastern Caribbean, with one of the highest income levels in the region: GDP of €11.3 billion in 2025 and GDP per capita of €29,500. Activity eased by 0.5% in volume in 2025 after 1.7% growth in 2024, but household consumption grew 1.2%, private investment rose 2.7% to €1.48 billion, bank credit increased 4.9% to €12.3 billion, and a record 9,150 businesses were created. Inflation is moderate at 1.3% in 2025 and 2.0% in June 2026, and IEDOM's business-climate indicator stood at 102.9 in the second quarter of 2026, above its long-term average. Tourism is regaining momentum, with hotel stays up 25.5% year on year in the second quarter of 2026. Separate FDI statistics are not published, but a €230 million port strategic programme, new hotel projects worth over €160 million and geothermal expansion point to sustained investor interest.

Guadeloupe's main structural challenge is renewing its infrastructure while its population declines and ages: residents numbered 384,160 in 2023, falling 0.3% a year as young people move to mainland France, and unemployment was 16.4% in mid-2026. The water network delivers only 45% of the water it produces, with full renewal estimated at €1.2 billion, and 86% of energy is imported. Mitigation is substantial: elected officials adopted an emergency water plan in June 2026, with the Département pledging €150 million over four years and a new public utility from January 2027, while the Albioma biomass conversion has raised renewables to about 45% of the electricity mix and geothermal capacity is set to more than triple by 2030. For investors, the opportunities lie in water and sanitation works, renewable energy, upscale tourism, port logistics and services for an ageing population.

## INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

### KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

| Issue | Potential Impact | Possible Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| Water network renewal | The network delivers only 45% of water produced, and the water operator carries about €160 million of debt, causing recurrent supply cuts | An emergency plan, €150 million from the Département and a new utility from 2027 create a large pipeline for engineering, leak-repair and water-treatment firms |
| Demographic decline and skills | The population is falling by 0.3% a year, unemployment was 16.4% in mid-2026 and 45% of hiring projects are judged difficult, notably in health and construction | Invest in local training and use ZFANG relief to lower costs; an ageing population creates growing demand in health, care and services |
| Construction and public-investment slowdown | Public investment fell 9.1% in 2025 and construction turnover was down 8.2% year on year in mid-2026 | Housing permits rose 25.5% over 12 months, and water, port and road programmes support a recovery in public works |
| Energy import dependence | 86% of energy consumed is imported, and renewables supplied 29.5% of electricity in 2024 | The biomass conversion at Le Moule and a geothermal target of 50 MW by 2030 open opportunities in renewables, storage and efficiency |
| Insularity and supply costs | Import dependence raises costs, and the goods and services trade deficit was €2.86 billion in 2025 | Port modernisation and the hub strategy improve logistics, while local agri-food processing can replace imports |

| Issue | Potential Impact | Possible Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| Tourism cyclicality | Tourist spending fell 6.7% in 2025 after an 18.5% surge in 2024 | Hotel stays rebounded 25.5% in the second quarter of 2026, with foreign visitors up 45.3%, and new upscale hotels are under way |
| Local governance and institutional evolution | The regional president was convicted at first instance on 30 September 2026 and is appealing, while elected officials are discussing greater autonomy within the Republic and the EU | Engage both the State and local authorities; any statutory change requires a lengthy organic-law process and Guadeloupe remains an EU outermost region |

### INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Guadeloupe's risk profile is that of a French and EU jurisdiction: legal, currency and transfer risks are low, contracts are enforced under French law, and the euro removes exchange-rate exposure for euro-area investors. Inflation is moderate, bank credit continues to grow and business sentiment remains above its long-term average, while tourism is recovering strongly in 2026. The main considerations are structural: a declining and ageing population, high unemployment, a water network in need of renewal and continued reliance on imported energy. On governance, Regional President Ary Chalus was convicted at first instance on 30 September 2026 of misusing public funds; he remains in office pending appeal, as the court did not order immediate ineligibility. Discussions on greater autonomy are a political process within the French constitutional framework, and the proposals keep Guadeloupe in the EU. Investors should take local tax advice, model incentives conservatively, and engage early with the Prefecture, the Région and the Département, while Guadeloupe's high incomes, EU standards and strategic Caribbean position offer a sound base for long-term investment.

### MARKET ACCESS

As a French overseas department and region, Guadeloupe is an outermost region of the European Union, fully within the EU single market and customs union and using the euro. Through France it is covered by WTO membership and EU trade agreements, including the EU–CARIFORUM Economic Partnership Agreement with its Caribbean neighbours. Its main exports are bananas, sugar and rum, alongside re-exports of petroleum products to French Guiana, and trade is oriented mainly towards mainland France. Guadeloupe Port Caraïbes is investing around €230 million under its strategic plan to develop transshipment for major shipping lines, with links across the Caribbean including Kingston, and the archipelago received about 250 cruise calls in 2025. Maryse Condé airport, with 2.1 million passengers in 2025, connects Guadeloupe with Europe, North America and the Caribbean.

## WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

### INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

| Actor | Why It Matters | Waverley Engagement Angle |
|---|---|---|
| Préfecture de la Guadeloupe (Prefect Thierry Devimeux) | Represents the French State, overseeing state services, security and state co-financing, including support for the water operator | Primary reference point for state policy, permitting and major public projects |
| Région Guadeloupe (President Ary Chalus) | Leads economic development, business aid and EU funds, including the ARICE grant and the €21 million Bpifrance partnership | Standard first point of contact for incentives and co-financing |
| IEDOM (Institut d'émission des départements d'outre-mer) | Acts as the Banque de France's arm in the overseas departments, monitoring credit, prices and the business climate | Authoritative source of economic and banking-sector intelligence |
| Conseil départemental (President Guy Losbar) | Leads the emergency water plan, pledging €150 million over four years, and champions the institutional-evolution process | Key partner for water, social and infrastructure projects |
| Guadeloupe Port Caraïbes (Grand Port Maritime de la Guadeloupe) | State port authority led by Jean-Pierre Chalus, delivering a €230 million strategic programme and the Quai 12 extension | Counterpart for logistics, transshipment and port-related investment |

| Actor | Why It Matters | Waverley Engagement Angle |
|---|---|---|
| Bpifrance and Banque des Territoires | Public investment banks financing SMEs, geothermal expansion and local infrastructure | Co-financing partners for business, energy and public-private projects |
| SMGEAG (water and sanitation operator) | Runs the water network until a new public utility takes over on 1 January 2027 | Counterpart for water-network contracts and service partnerships |

## CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Région Guadeloupe, working with Bpifrance, is the main channel for business support, guarantees and innovation finance, and the Chamber of Commerce and Industry of the Îles de Guadeloupe provides local business liaison. Banque des Territoires and AFD are the principal public financiers for infrastructure, energy and local-authority projects, and IEDOM publishes regular, detailed economic intelligence. Guadeloupe Port Caraïbes markets the island to shipping lines at international events such as Seatrade in Miami, Hamburg and Malaga, and the congresses of elected officials convened on water and institutional reform are useful forums for understanding local priorities. Operators such as Albioma and Ormat are a source of practical intelligence on the energy transition.

## INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Guadeloupe suits investors seeking a secure, euro-denominated EU base in the Caribbean with high local incomes: water, sanitation and civil-engineering firms positioned for a major network-renewal programme; renewable-energy, geothermal and storage investors supporting the shift away from imported fuel; hotel and leisure developers targeting the upscale market as tourism rebounds; logistics and distribution firms using the port's transshipment ambitions; and health, care and services providers serving an ageing population. Agri-food and rum producers can use enhanced 80% ZFANG relief to expand local processing and exports.

## FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the Région, the Département and the Prefecture
Open dialogue with the regional economic-development services, the departmental council and state services to identify priority sectors, sites, permits and co-financing.

STEP 2: Model ZFANG and overseas investment tax aid
Take local tax advice to confirm eligibility for the 50% or enhanced 80% ZFANG abatement and overseas investment tax aid, and track the renewal of EU state-aid coverage beyond 2026.

STEP 3: Position for the water-renewal programme
Follow the emergency water plan, the Plan Eau and the transfer to a new public utility in January 2027 to identify engineering, works and service contracts.

STEP 4: Explore energy-transition partnerships
Approach geothermal, biomass and solar operators and public financiers on projects supporting the 50 MW geothermal target and the wider renewable mix.

STEP 5: Use the port and tourism pipeline as a regional platform
Leverage the Quai 12 extension, the transshipment strategy and new upscale hotel projects to build Caribbean-wide logistics and hospitality operations.